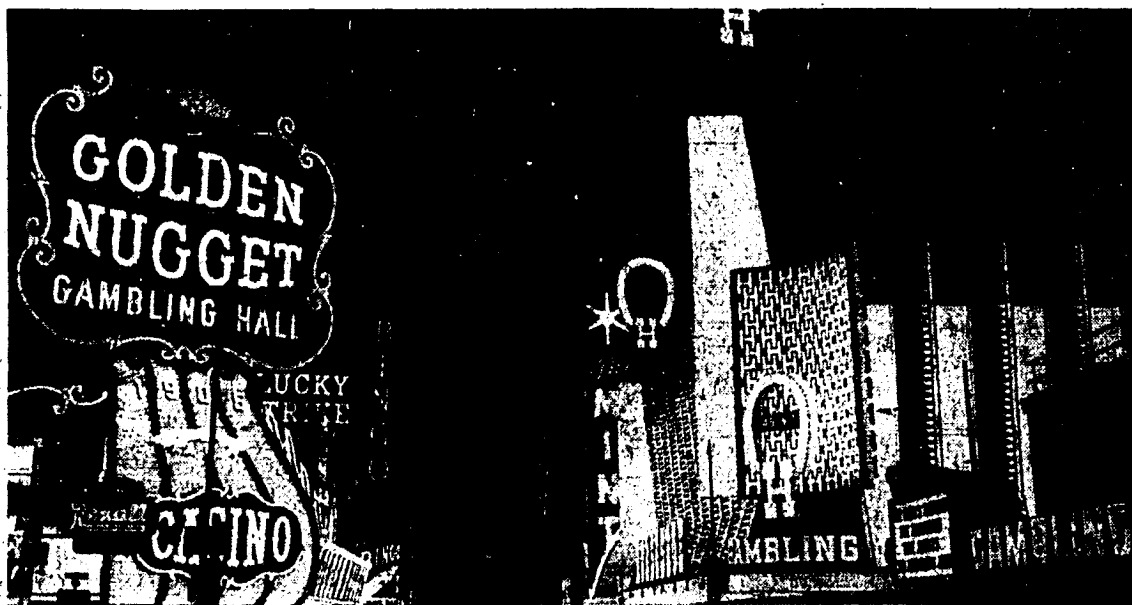




Architecture's gurus of the garish

LEARNING FROM LAS VEGAS (revised edition), by Robert Venturi, Denise Scott Brown and Steven Izenour. MIT Press. \$9.95 (paper).

By Robert Campbell

First published in 1972, "Learning from Las Vegas" was a successful effort by architecture's most deliberately infuriating iconoclasts and self-propagandists to bait the establishment.

Robert Venturi, his wife and partner Denise Scott Brown, and Steven Izenour sang the praises of the architecture of A&P parking lots and the Las Vegas Strip, while thumbing their noses at more stylish modern architects for being insensitive to such beauties.

The original book was a glossy gas-guzzler. MIT designed the hell-out of it, meaning acres of white space and skinny unreadable sans-serif text. The new edition is a much more useful paperback, though still not cheap at \$9.95.

The Venturis' writing is like Shaw's or Oscar Wilde's. They grab attention by turning received values topsy-turvy. "The A&P parking lot is a current phase in the evolution of vast space since Versailles" is

a fair sample of this shock-Aunt-Tildy style.

It isn't really the A&P or the Strip the Venturis love, though. What they love, and learn from, is signs. A big flashy sign in front of a boring little building is what the A&P has in common with the Vegas casino. Signs may be garish, but to the Venturis they're also liberating. A Las Vegas neon nightmare that juxtaposes Jack Benny, a classical pediment, and the Shell Oil emblem demonstrates to them "the vitality that may be achieved by an architecture of inclusion or, by contrast, the deadness that results from too great a preoccupation with tastefulness and total design." Of course, they're right.

Signs also lead the Venturis into the subject of architecture as communication, a topic that has since come to dominate criticism. Architects, they say, shouldn't invent new shapes or details that will have meaning only for other architects. Instead, they should start from the visual ideas ordinary people already have — maybe twisting these ideas, playing ironic games with them, but never abandoning them. Buildings must become "Ugly and Ordinary," not "Heroic and Original."

"Learning from Las Vegas" is also the

book that contains the famous division of all buildings into two kinds: "Ducks" (those that communicate a message through their physical form, like Boston City Hall) and "Decorated Sheds" (those whose message is not in the building but attached as a sign). Even Amiens cathedral is "a billboard with a building behind it."

The Venturis have chips on their shoulders and some of the claims they make for popular design and the car culture are extravagant. But they've been the most important figures — not only in the US, but internationally — in opening to question what had become the closed ideology of architectural modernism.

"Learning from Las Vegas," like all they write, is as crammed with ideas, as confused, contradictory and hard to find your way around in as they say architecture itself should be. By now, the book is an indispensable classic. Nearly everything from the original is here except the discussions of the Venturis' own buildings, which are rarely as good as their ideas anyway.

Robert Campbell, an architect, writes a column on architecture for *The Sunday Globe*.